GETTING PAID · THE PAPERWORK

Your first international invoice, in six pieces of paper.

What an Indian freelancer or consultant needs before a client abroad can pay them without a mess later. Saved by people who learned it the expensive way.

01 · THE CONTRACT

One page. Signed before you start.

Scope, in three lines

What you deliver, by when, what is out of scope.

Rate and currency

Fixed fee or day rate. USD, EUR or GBP. Never 'to be discussed'.

Payment within 15 days

Half up front on anything over $2,000.

IP transfers on payment

Not on delivery. They own it when you are paid.

30 days' notice, either side

So nobody is trapped.

We give the template away free. Link in the first comment.

02 · THE INVOICE

What goes on it that an Indian invoice usually misses.

Your name, PAN, address

And GSTIN if you have one.

Client's legal name and country

Their registered address, not a first name and an email.

Currency and amount in words

'USD 2,000 (two thousand US dollars)'.

The export line, if GST-registered

'Supply meant for export under LUT without payment of IGST'.

How to pay you

Skydo or Wise or Payoneer details. Not a bare SWIFT code with no instructions.

03 · THE PURPOSE CODE

Every inward remittance needs one. Pick it, don't let the bank guess.

P0802
Software consultancy and implementation

P0807
Other IT services: support, data processing, hosting

P1006
Business and management consultancy, PR

P1007
Advertising, trade fair, market research

P1099
Other services not covered above (design, writing, tutoring often land here)

The wrong code means a call from the bank and a delay. Skydo and Payoneer ask you for it up front; a plain bank wire may not.

04 · FIRA

The certificate that proves the money came from abroad.

Foreign Inward Remittance Advice

One per payment. It shows the sender, the currency, the amount, the purpose code.

Why you need it

GST zero-rating on exports, and the day a tax notice asks where ₹18 lakh came from.

Where it comes from

Skydo: instant, included. Payoneer: free, digital. Banks: ask, and often pay for it.

Keep every FIRA in one folder with its invoice. Future you, at tax time, will be grateful.

05 · GST AND THE LUT

Export of services is zero-rated. Only if you file one form a year.

Register above ₹20 lakh

Mandatory once turnover crosses it, even if 100% is export.

File the LUT (form RFD-11)

Every financial year, online, before you invoice. Then you charge no IGST.

Still file GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B

Zero-rated is not the same as exempt from filing.

Get paid in foreign currency

Receipt in INR without FIRC can cost you the export status.

Rules as we understand them in November 2026. Confirm with a CA before you rely on any of this.

06 · INCOME TAX

Section 44ADA: declare half, skip the books.

Presumptive scheme for professionals

Declare 50% of gross receipts as profit. No audited books.

Limit ₹50 lakh

₹75 lakh if at least 95% of receipts are digital, which for this work they are.

Advance tax

One instalment by 15 March. Miss it and interest runs.

Renumbered from 1 April 2026

The Income-tax Act 2025 changes section numbers. Search 'presumptive taxation for professionals', not '44ADA'.

If your real expenses are far below 50%, this scheme is a gift. If they are above, keep books instead.

Six pieces of paper. One evening.

Contract, invoice, purpose code, FIRA, LUT, 44ADA. Save this for the week your first client abroad says yes. The one-page contract template is free in the first comment.

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